Skill Misfit after Injection: Revising and Withdrawing Retrieved Skills for LLM Agents

Anonymous ACL submission

Abstract

LLM agents increasingly load *skills*: short procedures retrieved for a task and injected into the prompt. Retrieval reads only the task description, so a skill can fit the goal yet mislead the agent as the episode unfolds. With a reasoning agent on ALFWorld, restoring the same states shows that the retrieved skills alone can cause failures: from states of games the agent wins without skills but loses with them, continuing with the skills fails in all 18 runs, whereas withdrawing them wins 11. We propose TRIM, a training-free method that scores how much the skills raise the likelihood of the agent's drafted response, reasoning included, and intervenes when they drive it: at the first firing an editor revises the skills, and if they drive the agent again they are withdrawn for the rest of the episode. With Qwen3-8B in thinking mode, TRIM wins 75, 71 and 65 of the 134 unseen test games in three runs, on average 10.3 more than the retrieved skills (7.7 points, 95% CI [2.0, 13.7]). It also leads with Qwen3-14B and on SRA-Bench ToolQA and beats one edit at injection and both stages at random steps. On development games, withdrawing the skills helps in episodes where the signal fires repeatedly and hurts where it fires once, so skills should be withdrawn selectively rather than dropped.

1 Introduction

Agent skills package procedures, tool use and applicability conditions into short texts that an agent can reuse across tasks (Anthropic, 2025; Li et al., 2026c; Xia et al., 2026). A skill is written once, before the tasks it will serve are seen, and one skill serves many tasks; at run time the agent retrieves several skills from the task description and injects them into its prompt. Whether the injected skills fit a particular run is therefore a separate question.

Skills do not always help: a skill can lead the agent into a wrong action, add cost without changing the outcome, or leave a failure unsolved (Dong et al., 2026; Han et al., 2026; Wang et al., 2026f; Li et al., 2026b). Part of this misfit is visible at injection, when a retrieved item does not fit the task. Part of it appears only as the episode unfolds: observations reveal what the task description does not, such as what the environment holds or which attempts have failed, so a skill that suited the task can stop suiting the current state while its text stays in the prompt and keeps steering later decisions.

Existing remedies address the first kind: they decide when and which skills enter the context (Chen et al., 2026; Li et al., 2026d), retrieve skills for each plan step (Wang et al., 2026a), rewrite them into a task guide before acting (Li et al., 2026b), or refine the library between episodes (Zhang et al., 2026c; Ouyang et al., 2026; Liu et al., 2026b). Each settles the skill text before it is used or after the episode ends; once a skill is in the context, none of them revisits it against what the episode reveals.

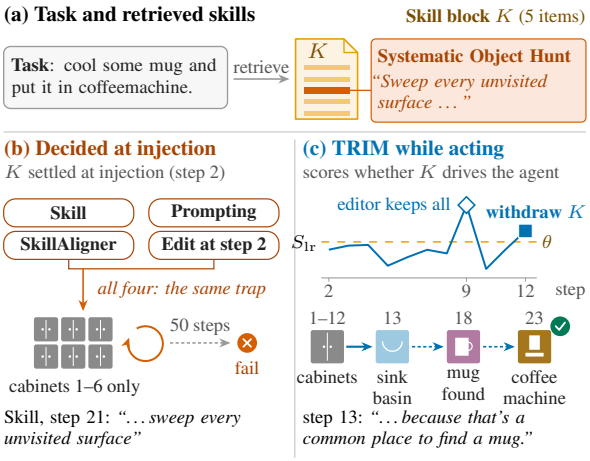


Figure 1: One test game (App. F). (a) The block retrieved from the goal holds a search routine. (b) Arms that settle the skills at injection stay in cabinets 1–6 for 50 steps. (c) TRIM has Skill's prompts up to step 12; S_{lr} fires at step 9 (the editor keeps all items) and at step 12 (block withdrawn), after which the agent leaves the cabinets and finds the mug. The agent without skills also finds it (32 steps). Icons in (c) skip steps.

Figure 1 shows the second kind: the block retrieved for cooling a mug holds a search routine; with it, the agent and every method that settles the skills at injection search cabinets 1–6 for all 50 steps, the Skill agent still citing it at step 21 ("sweep every unvisited surface"), whereas the agent without skills finds the mug. An edit at step 2 keeps the search item, and the SkillAligner guide also ends there.

TRIM therefore revisits the injected skills during the episode, at the steps they steer: it scores the drafted response with and without the skill block and takes the log-likelihood ratio, S_{lr}, as the skills' influence on the step, counting the reasoning in which the agent settles its action (Figure 2b). A high S_{lr} does not mean that the skills are wrong, only that they shape this step, making it a candidate for misfit. At the first firing an editor checks the items against the task and the observations and keeps, withholds or rewrites them, removing items that no longer fit and keeping the rest; if the revised block again drives the agent, the pull comes from the block itself, and TRIM withdraws it, not earlier, since removing skills also removes their help.

We evaluate on the 134 unseen test games of ALFWorld (Shridhar et al., 2021) and on 300 questions of SRA-Bench ToolQA (Su et al., 2026; Zhuang et al., 2023), with Qwen3-8B and Qwen3-14B in thinking mode (Yang et al., 2025). TRIM wins 75, 71 and 65 games in three runs, on average 10.3 more than the retrieved skills (7.7 points, 95% CI $[2.0, 13.7]$; 19:4 games in its first run, $p = 0.003$); it also leads with Qwen3-14B and on ToolQA, and beats one edit at step 2 and both stages at random steps. Our contributions are:

- A study of skill misfit with a reasoning agent: from the same states, the retrieved skills fail where withdrawing them succeeds (§3).
- TRIM, a training-free method in which the drafted response's likelihood with and without the skills decides when to revise and then withdraw them; to our knowledge, no prior method uses a model-internal signal to edit or withdraw an injected skill mid-episode (§4).
- Experiments on ALFWorld and ToolQA with two backbones, with ablations, and an analysis showing that withdrawal must be selective (§5–6).

2 Related Work

Agent skills. Agents keep experience as reusable skills, insights and workflows (Wang et al., 2024; Zhao et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025b; Xia et al., 2026); packaged as agent skills in the prompt (Anthropic, 2025), curated skills raise average pass rates (Li et al., 2026c). Later work refines or grows skill libraries (Zhang et al., 2026c; Ouyang et al., 2026; Liu et al., 2026b; Ju et al., 2026; Wang et al., 2026c), retrieves skills for each plan step (Wang et al., 2026a), learns when to invoke them (Chen et al., 2026) or which to inject (Li et al., 2026d), and adapts them into a task guide (Li et al., 2026b); most of these act between episodes or before the agent acts.

Skill misfit and adaptation. Skills can also cause failures an agent would not make without them (Dong et al., 2026): gains come with regressions (Tank and Nama, 2026), not every skill helps (Wang et al., 2026f), and gains shrink under realistic retrieval (Liu et al., 2026a) and larger libraries (Song and Wei, 2026); retrieved skills and memories can help in one state and mislead in another (Tu et al., 2026; Yuan et al., 2026; Ji et al., 2026). Our pairing (Figure 5; §3) adds a rerun-noise baseline and continuations from the same states with and without the skills. Other methods adapt context during an episode: they re-retrieve exemplars by the agent's current thought, select guidelines for the identified context, or revise plans from environment feedback (App. A); none of them checks whether the injected skills are driving the agent.

Signals. Adaptive retrieval decides when to consult external knowledge from uncertainty and internal states (Jiang et al., 2023; Su et al., 2024), and concurrent work reads model internals to select skills (Lin et al., 2026) or to localize turns for offline skill revision (Zhang et al., 2026b). TRIM instead revises and, if the misfit persists, withdraws the skills within one attempt, with an unchanged executor: its trigger contrasts the likelihood of the drafted response, reasoning included, with and without the skills, the pointwise form of CXMI (Fernandes et al., 2021, 2023) that PECoRe thresholds (Sarti et al., 2024) (other uses: App. A), used only to trigger an intervention at inference time.

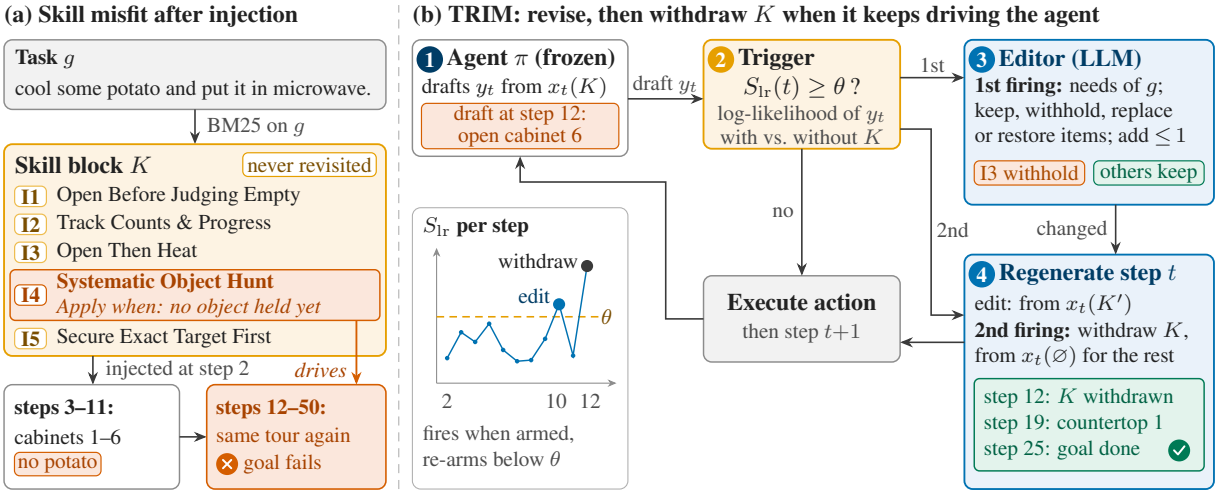


Figure 2: TRIM on one ALFWorld game (Qwen3-8B, thinking; App. F). (a) The block retrieved from the goal is never revisited: while no object is held, the search item I4 keeps applying, and the agent tours the cabinets and the fridge until step 50. (b) When the armed Trigger finds that the block drives the drafted response ($S_{\mathrm{lr}} \geq \theta$), the first firing sends the block to the Editor (step 10: the heating item I3 is withheld) and the second withdraws it (step 12); the step is regenerated, and without the block the agent reaches the countertop and wins.

3 Motivating Analysis

We compare the agent without the skill block (NoSkill) and with the block as retrieved (Skill), using Qwen3 in thinking mode on ALFWorld (§5.1); counts come from the first test run unless the development games are named.

Outcome changes. We pair NoSkill and Skill on each test game (Figure 5). With Qwen3-8B, the block raises wins only from 57 to 60 but changes the outcome of 45 games: it loses 21 of NoSkill's 57 wins and gains 24 games. With Qwen3-14B it raises wins from 61 to 63, losing 15 of NoSkill's wins and gaining 17. On the development games, where each arm ran twice, the block changes 35 of 140 outcomes, against 19 and 13 between two runs of NoSkill and of Skill, and it loses 14 of NoSkill's 64 wins, where a second NoSkill run loses 7. By task type, the block gains mostly on Clean (12 games against 2 lost) and loses on Cool (8 lost, 5 gained) and PickTwo (4 lost, none gained).

Same-state continuations. To hold the history fixed, we restored 12 states of development episodes with the block (six from games the skills harm, three from games they help and three from games that fail either way) and continued each three times with the block unchanged, with the block as revised by the editor of §4, and without the block (App. B). From the six harmed states, the unchanged block wins 0 of 18 continuations, the edited block 8 and no block 11; from the three helped states, 7, 6 and 6 of 9. The same state thus fails with the skills and succeeds without them, and withdrawing the block recovers more wins than editing it, at the cost of one win in nine where the skills help.

Failure patterns. Reading the 15 development games that the skills harm, we find two patterns (App. B). In nine, the agent never finds the target: 91% and 98% of its moves in the two Skill runs go to closed containers, against 59% and 63% without skills, and in six its reasoning cites a search item ("Systematic Object Hunt") in 37 to 48 of 49 steps. In four, BM25 attached a procedure written for another task type through a shared word, such as a cooling item in a heating task whose destination is the fridge; across the development heating games whose block holds that item, Skill wins none of 8 in either run and NoSkill 2 and 4. The other two failures are unrelated to the skills.

Accumulation within an episode. A search item does its harm by repetition: in the game of Figure 2, Skill circles through six cabinets and the fridge until step 50 and still cites "Systematic Object Hunt" at step 21, whereas NoSkill checks the countertop at step 3 and wins in 9 steps. A procedure for another task acts once its state arrives: in a development game that asks to heat a tomato and put it in the fridge, the agent cools the tomato right after heating it at step 26 because "the 'Enforce Cooling Before Placement' takes precedence", heats it again at step 45 and cools it again at step 47. Nei-

ther failure is visible in the task description, and both build up over steps that the retrieved text keeps steering.

4 Method

TRIM leaves the agent unchanged and controls only which skill block it sees: a *Trigger* decides when to change the injected block by scoring how strongly it drives the agent's next response (§4.2), and a *two-stage intervention* decides how, with an *Editor* revising the block at the first firing and withdrawal at the second (§4.3; Figure 2b, Algorithm 1).

4.1 Problem Setting

We consider an LLM agent π that solves a task, described by a goal g, by interacting with an environment. At each step t the agent receives an observation o_t and the set of admissible actions $\mathcal{A}_t$, and selects an action a_t; the episode succeeds ($R = 1$) if the goal state is reached within T steps and fails ($R = 0$) otherwise. We write $\tau_t = (o_0, a_1, o_1, \ldots, o_t)$ for the history up to step t.

Skills are retrieved once, from the goal alone. Given a skill library $\mathcal{L}$ and a relevance score r, the retriever returns the skill block

$$K = \underset{s \in \mathcal{L}}{\text{top-}k}\ r(g, s) = \{\kappa_1, \ldots, \kappa_k\}, \qquad (1)$$

whose items κ_j are short procedures, some stating when they apply. The block enters the prompt at step t_0, and K_t denotes the block in effect at step t, so that $K_t = K$ unless it is changed during the episode. The agent then generates a reasoning trace z_t followed by an action,

$$y_t = (z_t, a_t) \sim \pi\big(\cdot \mid x_t(K_t)\big), \qquad (2)$$

where $x_t(B)$ is the prompt built from g, the recent history, o_t and $\mathcal{A}_t$ with block B, and $x_t(\varnothing)$ is the same prompt without skills. TRIM may score y_t and replace it before its action is executed, so we call y_t the *draft*. In our experiments r is BM25, $k = 5$, $t_0 = 2$ and $T = 50$ (App. C).

Misfit after injection. Since K is fixed before any observation, whether it helps depends on the states the episode reaches. Let $V(\tau_t, B) = \Pr[R = 1 \mid \tau_t, B]$ be the probability of success when the episode continues from τ_t with block B in the prompt. We say that the block misfits at τ_t if some modification B' of K_t, possibly the empty block, attains $V(\tau_t, B') > V(\tau_t, K_t)$; a block that fits at t_0 can misfit later (§3). As V cannot be observed during an episode, TRIM decides from signals available to the agent itself when to change the block (§4.2) and how (§4.3), setting $K_{t+1} \in \{K_t,\ E(K_t),\ \varnothing\}$, so that a misfitting block is changed, a helpful one is kept, and interventions remain rare.

Algorithm 1 TRIM in one episode. The first firing sends the block to the editor; a second firing withdraws it for the rest of the episode.

Require: goal g; block K (BM25 on g); agent π; editor E; θ

$armed \leftarrow$ **true**; $n \leftarrow 0$ ▷ firings so far
for $t = 1, \ldots, 50$ **do**
  $y_t \leftarrow \pi\big(x_t(K)\big)$ ▷ reasoning, then action
  if $t \geq t_0$ **and** $K \neq \varnothing$ **then**
    $s \leftarrow S_{\text{lr}}(t)$ ▷ Eq. (4), whole response
    if $armed$ **and** $s \geq \theta$ **then** ▷ trigger fires
      $armed \leftarrow$ **false**; $n \leftarrow n + 1$
      if $n = 1$ **then** ▷ stage 1: review
        $K \leftarrow E.\textsc{Review}(K, g, \text{episode}, y_t)$
      else ▷ stage 2: withdraw
        $K \leftarrow \varnothing$
      if K changed **then** $y_t \leftarrow \pi\big(x_t(K)\big)$
    else if not $armed$ **and** $s < \theta$ **then**
      $armed \leftarrow$ **true** ▷ re-arm
  execute the action in y_t; **stop** if the episode ends

4.2 Trigger

A skill can mislead the agent only at the steps it drives: when the draft is about as likely without the block, changing the block would change little, whereas when the draft is much more likely with it, the reasoning and the action follow the retrieved text, and a change to the block can still alter the choice. The Trigger therefore asks how much less likely the agent would be to produce the draft without the skills, not, as uncertainty signals in adaptive retrieval do (Jiang et al., 2023; Su et al., 2024), whether it lacks information. A high score marks where a skill-induced wrong choice can occur, not where one does: helpful skills raise it too, and the intervention decides between the two.

Score. For the draft y_t the Trigger compares each token's log-probability with and without the block,

$$c_{t,i} = \log \frac{\pi\big(y_{t,i} \mid x_t(K_t),\ y_{t,<i}\big)}{\pi\big(y_{t,i} \mid x_t(\varnothing),\ y_{t,<i}\big)}, \qquad (3)$$

the pointwise cross-mutual information (P-CXMI) of token $y_{t,i}$ with the block as context (Fernandes et al., 2021, 2023), and averages it over the whole

response, reasoning included:

$$S_{\mathrm{lr}}(t) = \frac{1}{|y_t|} \sum_{i=1}^{|y_t|} c_{t,i}. \tag{4}$$

We include the reasoning because a thinking agent settles its action there: over the action tokens alone, S_{lr} is almost always zero (median 0.00, against 0.36 over the whole response; App. C.3). Writing $\pi_B = \pi(\cdot \mid x_t(B))$, the sum $|y_t|\, S_{\mathrm{lr}}(t)$ estimates $\mathrm{KL}(\pi_{K_t} \,\|\, \pi_{\varnothing})$, how far the block moves the agent's response distribution (exactly so only for untempered sampling; App. C). Scoring prefills the draft under both prompts and generates nothing (cost in App. E).

Firing rule. A firing marks a step at which the block strongly drives the draft. A run of high scores should count as one event, so the Trigger carries an armed state α_t, with $\alpha_{t_0} = 1$:

$$f_t = \alpha_t \, \mathbb{I}\big[S_{\mathrm{lr}}(t) \geq \theta\big], \qquad \alpha_{t+1} = \mathbb{I}\big[S_{\mathrm{lr}}(t) < \theta\big], \tag{5}$$

where $f_t = 1$ is a firing; steps that are not scored (before t_0, after a withdrawal, or with no action in the draft) leave α unchanged. Requiring the score to fall below θ before the next firing also gives a revised block the chance to take effect before the second stage. We write $n_t = \sum_{t' \leq t} f_{t'}$ for the number of firings so far.

Threshold. With Θ the scores of an observation run of the Skill arm on the development games (every step scored, no intervention; 138 episodes) and $\bar{N}(\theta')$ the mean number of firings per episode at threshold θ', we set before any test run

$$\theta = \min\{\theta' \in \Theta : \bar{N}(\theta'') \leq 1.5 \;\; \forall\, \theta'' \geq \theta'\}, \tag{6}$$

with $\theta'' \in \Theta$, which gives $\theta = 0.9387$, reached by 5.9% of the scored steps; the condition on all larger θ'' is needed because $\bar{N}$ is not monotone (App. C.3).

4.3 Two-Stage Intervention

Retrieved skills cause failures in two ways (§3), and the two stages target them in turn, so that TRIM changes what drives the agent rather than only resampling the failing step. A single item can misfit the task, such as a procedure for another task type; withholding or replacing it removes the wrong instruction and keeps the items that help, so the first firing calls the Editor. Reliance on the block can also persist: a search routine spans several items and drives the agent over many steps, which an item-level edit can leave in place; if the edited block again drives the agent, the source is the block rather than one item, and withdrawing it returns the agent to its own choices. Withdrawing at the first firing would also remove the skills where they help: it recovers more continuations from harmed states than editing (§3) but keeps fewer of the games that need the skills (§5.3).

Update rule. The intervention thus escalates with the number of firings. With E the Editor and f_t, n_t from Eq. (5), the block for step t becomes

$$K_t^+ = \begin{cases} E(K_t, h_t) & f_t = 1,\ n_t = 1 \text{ (revise)}, \\ \varnothing & f_t = 1,\ n_t = 2 \text{ (withdraw)}, \\ K_t & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{7}$$

where h_t is the Editor's view of the episode (Stage 1 below), and $K_{t+1} = K_t^+$. If $K_t^+ \neq K_t$, step t is regenerated, $y_t \sim \pi(\cdot \mid x_t(K_t^+))$, with a new seed, and the regenerated action is executed. The second firing counts whether or not the first review changed the block, so an episode has at most one Editor review, at most one withdrawal and at most two regenerated steps.

Stage 1: Editor. At the first firing, the Editor, the agent's own model with thinking off, reads the task, the initial observation and the last eight steps, the drafted action with the end of its reasoning, and the block, and gives each item κ_j a verdict $v_j \in \{\textsc{keep}, \textsc{withhold}, \textsc{replace}(\kappa_j')\}$. With h_t this input, the edited block is

$$E(K_t, h_t) = \big[\rho(\kappa_j, v_j)\big]_{j:\, v_j \neq \textsc{withhold}} \oplus u, \tag{8}$$

where $\rho(\kappa, \textsc{keep}) = \kappa$, $\rho(\kappa, \textsc{replace}(\kappa')) = \kappa'$, and u is an optional instruction for a step the task needs and no item covers. KEEP is the default; an item is withheld when following it conflicts with the task or the observations, and replaced when its idea serves the task but a detail is wrong. The Editor never sees S_{lr} or any outcome; it first lists what the task requires in a separate call that sees only the task sentence (prompts in App. C.4).

Stage 2: Withdrawal. At the second firing the Editor is not called. The block is withdrawn for the rest of the episode, $K_{t'} = \varnothing$ for all $t' \geq t$, and step t is regenerated from $x_t(\varnothing)$. The agent continues from its current state with the no-skill prompt, and the Trigger stops scoring, so each later step costs

	ALFWorld: success (%)							SRA-Bench ToolQA: accuracy (%)						
Method	Pick	Heat	Cool	Clean	Look	PickTwo	All	Flt.	Cof.	Yelp	Abnb.	Agd.	DBLP	All
Qwen3-8B (thinking)														
Baselines														
NoSkill	45.8	39.1	66.7	29.0	50.0	29.4	42.5	14.0	38.0	48.0	22.0	16.0	20.0	26.3
Skill (BM25 top-5)	37.5	43.5	52.4	61.3	55.6	5.9	44.8	54.0	64.0	58.0	42.0	8.0	20.0	41.0
+ prompting	50.0	47.8	61.9	61.3	55.6	11.8	50.0	56.0	64.0	50.0	40.0	6.0	26.0	40.3
SkillAligner	70.8	22.7	47.6	58.1	50.0	35.3	48.9	50.0	40.0	52.0	32.0	8.0	10.0	32.0
Planning‡	51.4	31.9	57.1	59.1	51.9	7.8	45.3	40.0	50.0	42.0	36.0	8.0	20.0	32.7
Ours														
TRIM	58.3	56.5	76.2	58.1	55.6	23.5	**56.0**	58.0	66.0	56.0	56.0	4.0	28.0	44.7
Qwen3-14B (thinking)														
Baselines														
NoSkill	72.2	39.1	44.4	40.9	50.0	5.9	43.5	36.0	44.0	58.0	36.0	10.0	30.0	35.7
Skill (BM25 top-5)	68.1	27.5	49.2	64.5	68.5	5.9	49.5	50.0	72.0	40.0	32.0	6.0	32.0	38.7
+ prompting	68.1	30.4	50.8	60.2	70.4	3.9	49.3	52.0	70.0	40.0	28.0	8.0	20.0	36.3
SkillAligner	76.4	24.6	47.6	64.5	61.1	19.6	51.0	54.0	52.0	52.0	42.0	0.0	14.0	35.7
Planning	65.3	30.4	47.6	60.2	63.0	11.8	48.3	46.0	54.0	40.0	20.0	10.0	22.0	32.0
Ours														
TRIM	83.3	26.1	61.9	54.8	72.2	23.5	54.5	62.0	72.0	52.0	44.0	8.0	44.0	47.0

Table 1: Main results with Qwen3 in thinking mode. ALFWorld: success on the 134 valid_unseen games per task type (games: 24, 23, 21, 31, 18, 17; SkillAligner finished 133 with Qwen3-8B), in the run that shares the baselines' seeds (TRIM: run 1; its three-run rate is in §5.2); Qwen3-14B baselines: three-run means (Qwen3-8B prompting and SkillAligner: run 1 shown, three-run comparison in Figure 7); TRIM with Qwen3-14B: one run so far. ‡Qwen3-8B Planning: three-run mean (runs: 41.8, 45.5, 48.5). ToolQA: accuracy on 300 questions, 50 per domain (Flt. Flights, Cof. Coffee, Abnb. Airbnb, Agd. Agenda). Green: interim (2026-10-12 11:46 UTC = 20:46 KST; App. D.3). Red: values of the assumed scenario (Limitations). –: not defined. Controls: App. Table 8.

what it costs the no-skill agent; the next episode starts again with the retrieved block. Table 2 removes each stage in turn, and §6 examines what each stage changes and where the signal fires.

5 Experiments

5.1 Experimental Setup

We evaluate on the 134 unseen games of ALFWorld (Shridhar et al., 2021; Côté et al., 2019) in the SkillRL harness (Xia et al., 2026) and on 300 questions of SRA-Bench ToolQA (Su et al., 2026; Zhuang et al., 2023), with Qwen3-8B and Qwen3-14B (Yang et al., 2025) in thinking mode; the block holds the five SkillBank skills ranked highest by BM25 (Robertson and Zaragoza, 2009). The baselines, NoSkill, Skill (the block as retrieved), *prompting* (a one-line instruction to adapt the skills), *SkillAligner* (Li et al., 2026b) and *Planning* (Wang et al., 2026a), differ from TRIM only in which skills reach the prompt and how they are handled. We report success rates and compare arms per game with exact sign tests and 95% bootstrap intervals (details in App. D.1).

5.2 Main Results

Overall. With Qwen3-8B (Table 1), retrieved skills raise success from 42.5% to 44.8%, prompting reaches 50.0% and SkillAligner 48.9%, while TRIM reaches 56.0% in the run that shares the baselines' seeds and 52.5% over its three runs. Adapting the skills before the agent acts thus adds 5.2 and 4.1 points to the retrieved skills, whereas revising and withdrawing them during the episode adds 11.2 points in that run. Its per-game success rate is 7.7 points above Skill's (95% CI $[2.0, 13.7]$) and 10.0 above NoSkill's ($[2.7, 17.2]$; App. Figure 7); its first run is ahead of Skill (19:4 games, $p = 0.003$) and NoSkill (28:10, $p = 0.005$) after a Holm adjustment (Holm, 1979).

Where the gains come from. The gains follow the misfit of §3. Where the retrieved skills hurt, TRIM recovers past the agent without skills: Cool rises from 52.4% with Skill to 76.2% (NoSkill 66.7%) and Pick from 37.5% to 58.3% (45.8%). Where they help, it keeps most of their gain on Clean (58.1%, against 61.3% with Skill and 29.0% without) and adds to it on Heat (56.5%, against 43.5% and 39.1%).

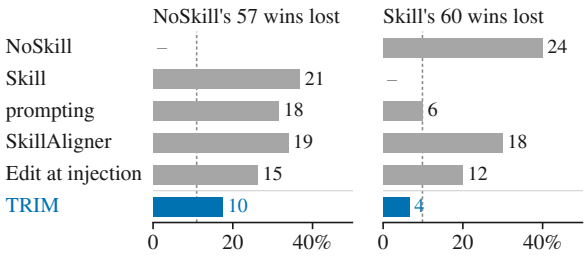


Figure 3: Wins of NoSkill (left) and of Skill (right) that each arm loses on the 134 test games (Qwen3-8B, thinking, run 1; SkillAligner: 133 games). Edit at injection (PRE): TRIM's editor run once, when the block is injected at step 2. Dashed: a second run of the same arm (development games).

Other backbone and benchmark. With Qwen3-14B (three runs), the retrieved skills raise success from 43.5% to 49.5%, prompting reaches 49.3% and SkillAligner 51.0%, and TRIM 54.5% in its first run, ahead of the first runs of NoSkill, Skill, prompting and SkillAligner in paired games (12:7 to 22:10; App. D.1); its largest gains over Skill are on PickTwo (23.5% against 5.9%), Pick (83.3% against 68.1%) and Cool (61.9% against 49.2%); on ToolQA TRIM answers 44.7% and 47.0% of the questions with the two backbones, ahead of every arm, and over three runs it wins more games than prompting and SkillAligner with each backbone (Qwen3-8B: 40:23 and 48:26 games; Qwen3-14B: 41:21 and 38:24; App. D.1).

Lost wins and cost. Deciding about the skills once, at injection, gives up wins on one side or both (Figure 3): keeping them loses 21 of NoSkill's 57 wins, dropping them loses 24 of Skill's 60, prompting still loses 18 of NoSkill's wins, and SkillAligner, which rewrites the skills before acting, 19 and 18. Even TRIM's editor, run once when the block is injected (PRE; App. D.6), loses 15 and 12. TRIM, which revises and withdraws the block during the episode, loses 10 and 4, the fewest of all arms with skills; a second run of NoSkill or Skill itself loses 7 of 64 and 7 of 71 wins on the development games. With Qwen3-14B it again loses the fewest of NoSkill's wins (10 of 61, against 12 to 15) and ties prompting on Skill's (7 of 63; App. D.1). On the 26 games that NoSkill, Skill, prompting, SkillAligner and TRIM all solve, TRIM takes 9.3 actions (Skill 8.2, NoSkill 11.5), and it generates 31.0k tokens per episode with editor calls, against 32.0k for Skill and 35.8k for SkillAligner (App. Table 5).

Variant	%	Harmed	Needed
TRIM (edit, then withdraw)	**52.5**	**9**/15	**15**/19
One stage changed			
Edit only (no withdrawal)	49.3	3/15	14/20
Withdraw at first firing (no edit)	51.4	7/15	10/20
Regenerate instead of edit	48.6	5/15	15/20
Random steps instead of the signal			
Random withdrawal	48.6	4/15	14/20
Both stages at random	49.3	5/15	16/20
No intervention (Skill)	50.0	(0/15)	(20/20)

Table 2: Components of TRIM on the 140 development games (Qwen3-8B, thinking; one run each, same seeds; %: of finished games). Harmed / Needed: wins among the 15 games the skills harm and the 20 that need them, set by Skill's and NoSkill's runs (hence Skill's values). Pairs: App. D.1; signal variants: App. Table 10.

5.3 Ablation Study

Table 2 changes one part of TRIM at a time on the development games, counting wins among the 15 games the skills harm and the 20 that need them; each stage covers one side. Without the withdrawal, 3 harmed games are won instead of 9; at the 42 states where TRIM withdrew, continuations without the block win 35.7% against 23.8% with it (+11.9 points, $[1.2, 22.6]$; Figure 4). Without the edit, withdrawing at the first firing keeps only 10 of the 20 games that need the skills, against 15 of 19, so withdrawal must be selective (§6). The signal times the withdrawal: at random steps 4 harmed games are won, and 5 with both stages random. TRIM also wins more test episodes than a one-time edit at step 2 or the same two stages at random steps (211 against 187 and 190 of 402, $p \leq 0.009$), and withdrawing at the signal's state helps more than at nearby or random states (App. D.8).

6 Analysis

Counts come from the first test run unless more runs or the development games are named.

Firing statistics. TRIM fires in 81 of the 134 test episodes of run 1, first at a median step of 4 (interquartile range 2–10); 64 of its 81 reviews change the block, and 34 episodes reach a second firing and withdraw the block, at a median step of 15 (9–20). Over the three runs, the first firing comes at a median step of 4 in every run (App. E). In the game of Figure 2, the edit at step 10 withholds the heating item but keeps both search items, the signal fires again at step 12, and after the withdrawal the agent revisits a few containers, then checks the sink

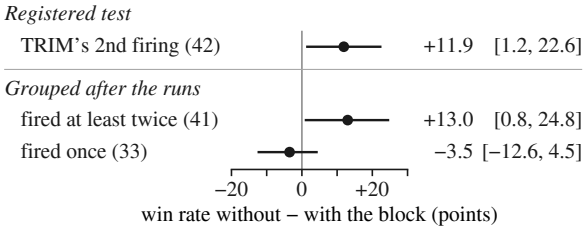


Figure 4: Withdrawing the block on restored development states (Qwen3-8B, thinking): win rate without the block minus with it, in points, with 95% bootstrap CIs. Top: the 42 states where TRIM withdrew, against keeping the edited block. Bottom: episodes grouped by whether the signal had fired at least twice or once by step 40, averaging three restored states each; the groups differ by 16.5 points, $[1.6, 32.0]$. Within an episode, withdrawing at the signal's state helps more than at the nearest or a random state without a firing (+9.5 and +10.1 points; App. Table 11).

basin and the countertop, finds the potato and wins at step 25 (Figure 2b).

Repeated firing and withdrawal. On the development observation run (no intervention), the rearmed Trigger fires 3.07 times per episode in the 15 games the skills harm, against 1.45 in the 20 games that need them and 0.59 in the 44 that every run wins; it fires at least twice in 11 of the harmed games, 8 of those that need the skills and 2 easy ones. To see whether withdrawing helps where the signal fires repeatedly, we restored 74 development episodes in which the signal fired, each at three of its states, and continued every state twice with the block and twice without it (App. D.8). In the 41 episodes where the signal fired at least twice, withdrawal raises the win rate by 13.0 points; in the 33 where it fired once, it lowers it by 3.5 points (difference 16.5 points, 95% CI $[1.6, 32.0]$; Figure 4).

Gains and losses of withdrawal. Split by how Skill and NoSkill fared on the game, withdrawal at the signal's state raises the win rate by 38.5 points in the games the skills harm and lowers it by 34.6 points in the games that need them (13 episodes each; App. Table 11), and in the same-state study it loses one win in nine where the skills help (§3). Removing the skills unconditionally would trade the games they harm for those they help: dropping them loses 24 of Skill's 60 test wins, whereas TRIM, which withdraws them only after a revision fails, loses 4 (Figure 3).

Effect of each stage. The edit removes procedures written for other tasks: on the test games, its 81 first reviews withhold or replace 57 of the 79 items written for another task type, and in edit-only development arms, in 109 of 129 drafts that planned a procedure the task does not ask for, the regenerated reasoning no longer did. A search routine instead spans several items and plays out over many steps, and the withdrawal ends it: in the game of Figure 2 the agent reaches the countertop seven steps after the withdrawal, and in the game of Figure 8 it leaves the cabinets at the next step.

A matched episode. In one test game, TRIM's first 12 prompts equal Skill's while both agents search the cabinets; after the block is withdrawn at step 12, the agent leaves the cabinets, finds the mug and wins, whereas Skill, prompting, SkillAligner and a one-time edit at step 2 stay among the cabinets for 50 steps (App. F, Figure 8).

7 Conclusion

A skill that fits the goal can still misfit the episode: with a reasoning agent on ALFWorld, the retrieved skills alone can make the agent fail from states where it would otherwise succeed, mostly by locking it into a search routine or another task's procedure. TRIM revises the injected skills when they drive the agent's drafted response and withdraws them if they keep driving it. In three test runs with Qwen3-8B, it wins 70.3 of 134 games on average, 10.3 more than the retrieved skills, and withdrawal helps where the signal fires repeatedly but hurts where it fires once, so skills should be withdrawn selectively rather than dropped. It also leads with Qwen3-14B and on ToolQA. Separating the misfits that skills cause from failures that happen anyway remains open. Skills should be revisited during execution, where they act.

Limitations

We evaluate TRIM with one model family, Qwen3, in thinking mode, on ALFWorld with one retrieved skill library and on SRA-Bench ToolQA; other environments, skill libraries written by people and other model families remain to be tested. The Trigger reads prompt log-probabilities, which many closed APIs do not expose, and scoring the drafted response with and without the block adds two prefills per step, 8.5% of an episode's wall-clock time with Qwen3-8B (App. E). TRIM revises or withdraws the retrieved block but does not write new skills, so failures whose procedure is missing from the library are outside its scope; the editor is the

agent's own checkpoint, and a stronger editor may revise blocks more precisely.

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A Extended Related Work

This section complements §2.

Context and revision during an episode. Misaligned, irrelevant or conflicting context misleads agents and LLMs (Xiong et al., 2026; Shi et al., 2023; Xu et al., 2024b; Cuconasu et al., 2024). During an episode, exemplars are re-retrieved (Zhou et al., 2024), guidelines selected (Fu et al., 2024) and plans revised (Sun et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2026e), and self-correction (Madaan et al., 2023;

Gou et al., 2024; Shinn et al., 2023) often fails without external feedback (Huang et al., 2024; Kamoi et al., 2024). Adaptive retrieval also uses reflection tokens (Asai et al., 2024) or further internal-state triggers (Mallen et al., 2023; Yao et al., 2025); agents seek experience (Zhang et al., 2026d) or, concurrently, a teacher (Bonetta et al., 2026) when their entropy is high, and concurrent work reads model internals to time history compression (Wang et al., 2026d).

Skills and when they are adapted. Task-level induced skills often transfer below a no-memory baseline (Feng et al., 2026), and verifier-gated pipelines decide whether to reuse or rewrite skill units (Yu et al., 2026). At injection, the concurrent SkillApt decides for each retrieved skill whether to load it, from evidence of past runs with and without it (Guo et al., 2026). Within an episode, LLM-Planner re-plans after failed actions (Song et al., 2023). These methods choose skills before acting or react to failures; TRIM keeps the executor unchanged and revises, then withdraws, the injected block when its likelihood contrast fires.

Filtering context. Retrieval pipelines compress or filter passages (Xu et al., 2024a), and filtering can discard relevant ones (Yoran et al., 2024); TRIM instead edits the guidance for the next action and can likewise withhold what the task needs (§6).

More on skills, plans and memories. Most public software-engineering skills leave pass rates unchanged (Han et al., 2026). Prompt optimizers refine instructions against a training score (Yang et al., 2024); cognitive architectures re-check rule preconditions at every decision cycle (Sumers et al., 2024); and planners check feasibility (Ichter et al., 2023) or use environment feedback (Huang et al., 2023).

Signals and on/off comparisons. Uncertainty signals often flag errors (Kadavath et al., 2022), and robot planners ask for help when uncertain (Ren et al., 2023); verbalized confidence is often too high (Xiong et al., 2024), and retrieved passages that are related but unhelpful lower accuracy more than random ones (Cuconasu et al., 2024).

Across adaptive-retrieval methods, simple uncertainty estimates often match more elaborate triggers (Moskvoretskii et al., 2025), and agents can reflect when their verbalized confidence calls for it (Zhang et al., 2026a). Such signals target an information need, whereas our trigger asks whether the skills drive the response. Concurrent work also argues that an agent's stated use of a skill does not reveal which decisions depend on it without an on/off comparison (Hu et al., 2026); our trigger makes that comparison for each drafted response until the block is withdrawn. The with/without-context contrast that our trigger uses also attributes generations to context (Cohen-Wang et al., 2024), reweights decoding (Shi et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2025a; van der Poel et al., 2022), selects prompts (Liu et al., 2025), trains skill-conditioned students (Wang et al., 2026b; Lu et al., 2026; Pan et al., 2026; Yang et al., 2026) and, concurrently, locates skill rules to revise between training cycles (Li et al., 2026a).

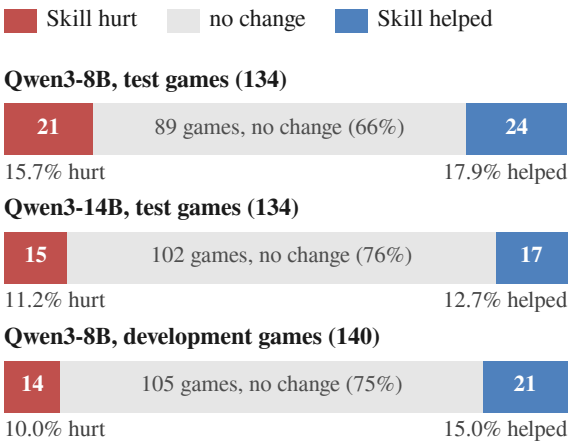


Figure 5: Where retrieved skills help and hurt (Qwen3 thinking, one run per arm). Hurt: NoSkill wins the game and Skill loses it; helped: the reverse; no change: both win or both lose. A second NoSkill run also changes 19 of the 140 development games.

B Motivating Analysis Details

B.1 Same-State Study

We sampled 12 games of a development run (seed fixed in advance), stratified by its outcomes: six that Skill lost and NoSkill won (harmed), three that Skill won and NoSkill lost (helped) and three that both lost. In each, we restored the Skill episode at step k, one step after the agent first picked up an object, or at step 3 if it never did, replaying the logged actions and checking that every restored prompt equals the logged one. From that state, each branch regenerates step k and continues to the 50-step limit three times (seeds fixed per branch), with no further intervention: A keeps the block, B uses the block as our editor revised it once (the first review of TRIM's editor, without the reasoning

State	Type	k	Keep	Edit	No block
Harmed (Skill lost, NoSkill won)					
S01	Heat	3	0/3	1/3	3/3
S02	Clean	3	0/3	2/3	1/3
S03	Cool	3	0/3	2/3	1/3
S04	Heat	30	0/3	1/3	1/3
S05	Heat	8	0/3	2/3	3/3
S06	Cool	3	0/3	0/3	2/3
Helped (Skill won, NoSkill lost)					
S07	Heat	45	2/3	2/3	0/3
S08	Clean	11	3/3	3/3	3/3
S09	Clean	6	2/3	1/3	3/3
Both lost					
S10–S12			0/9	0/9	0/9

Table 3: Same-state study on development states (Qwen3-8B, thinking): wins of three continuations per branch from the restored state at step k.

excerpt, which was added later), and N removes it (the no-skill prompt). A minimal editor allowed only to withhold one item kept every block and is not listed. Table 3 gives every state; four of the six harmed episodes never picked anything up, so their states are at step 3. Twelve states with three continuations each are a diagnostic, not a test.

B.2 Games the Skills Harm

Three analysts read the trajectories of the 15 development games that Skill lost in both of its runs while NoSkill won at least one. **Search tunnels (9 games).** In both Skill runs the agent never observed the target, and no Skill episode visited the place where NoSkill picked it up; 91% and 98% of Skill's moves went to closed containers, against 59% and 63% for NoSkill. In six games the reasoning cites "Systematic Object Hunt" in 37 to 48 of 49 steps; in the other three the item is rarely cited and NoSkill starts with the same tour, so the skills may not be the cause there. **Procedures for another task (4 games).** BM25 attached a state-change item for another task type through a shared word, such as "Enforce Cooling Before Placement" in heating tasks whose destination is the fridge, or "Open Then Heat" in cooling tasks whose destination is the microwave. Over all development games, heating games with the cooling item are won in 0 of 8 by both Skill runs and in 2 and 4 by NoSkill; cooling games with the heating item in 0 and 1 of 6 by Skill and 4 and 4 by NoSkill. **Unrelated (2 games).** One agent took a failed pick-up for a success, and one read "cool" as already cold, as NoSkill also did once.

What the editor does. Pooled over the development arms that only edit, the editor's 1,840 first-review verdicts are 998 keep, 732 withhold and 110 replace. It withholds most items written for other task types (410 of 574), but also half of the items for the task's own operation (276 of 551), 174 of them with a reason that denies the operation is needed, such as "already clean"; it almost never withholds generic search items (46 of 715) and kept "Open Before Judging Empty" in all 134 verdicts on it. 89% of the evidence for its first edits is the task sentence alone. Accepted edits changed the step's action in 9% of cases (43 of 477), below the 17% at which resampling alone changes an action, but they changed the plan: in 109 of the 129 drafts that planned an operation of another task type, the regenerated reasoning no longer did. On the test games, TRIM's editor (which sees the reasoning excerpt) withholds or replaces, in its 81 first reviews, 57 of the 79 items written for another task type, 26 of the 86 items for the task's own operation and 7 of the 49 search items; 64 of the 81 reviews change the block.

B.3 Run-to-Run Noise

With the same prompts and seeds, batched serving makes runs diverge: 19–28% of games differ in the first step, and each step before an edit diverges with probability 0.17. Without any edit, 9.4% of outcomes (13 of 139 games) differ between two Skill runs, and the difference in wins between two runs of 140 games has a standard deviation of about 3.7. Detecting a gain of 5 games in 140 with power 0.8 would need about 920 paired games, i.e., about seven repeats of the 140 games.

C Method Details

This appendix documents TRIM as it ran in all thinking-mode test runs; every setting was fixed on the 140 valid_seen games before any test run.

C.1 Agent Harness and Retrieval

Harness. We port SkillRL's ALFWorld agent loop (Xia et al., 2026) string for string: prompt templates, history format (the last two observation–action pairs), admissible-action list (without `help`) and action parser. Step 1 uses SkillRL's no-history template without skills; from step 2 on, the block appears under `## Retrieved Relevant Experience`. The parser takes the lower-cased text inside the first `<action>...</action>` of the answer, after the reasoning; if a tag is missing, the

last 30 characters of the output are sent to the environment, which answers "Nothing happens.". An episode ends with success or after 50 actions.

Decoding. The agent is Qwen3-8B (Yang et al., 2025) with thinking enabled in its chat template, sampled with temperature 0.6, top-p 0.95 and top-k 20 (no penalties), at most 4,096 output tokens per response, and served with vLLM (Kwon et al., 2023) and its reasoning parser, which returns the reasoning and the answer separately. Each request carries a seed derived from the game, the step and the request kind (draft, regeneration), so that all arms draw the same seed for the same game and step; batched serving can still make two requests with one seed differ.

Retrieval. The skill bank is SkillRL's released SkillBank with 44 retrievable skills (12 general, 32 task-specific; its 11 "common mistakes" form a fixed section and are not retrieved). Each skill is indexed as "title. principle. when_to_apply" and the query is the goal sentence. We rank with Okapi BM25 (Robertson and Zaragoza, 2009) (k_1=1.5, b=0.75, lower-cased alphanumeric tokens, no stemming or stop-word removal) and keep the top five. General skills are rendered as `- **title**: principle` under `### General Principles` and task skills as the same line plus an indented `_Apply when: ..._` line under `### Task-Relevant Skills`.

C.2 Computing S_{lr}

The drafted response is rebuilt as `<think>`, the reasoning, `</think>` and the answer, and tokenized once. Each of the two prompts, $x_t(K)$ and $x_t(\varnothing)$, is chat-templated with thinking enabled and followed by these token ids, and one prefill returns the log-probability of every response token (temperature 0, one generated token, top-5 prompt log-probabilities). S_{lr} is the mean difference over all response tokens, in nats per token. $x_t(\varnothing)$ is the no-skill agent's prompt in the same state; the skill-off term rescores the same tokens and never regenerates the response without the block. A draft without an action in its answer is not scored and cannot fire. The same prefills give the other candidate signals of App. C.3: the ratio over the action tokens only, over the reasoning only or over its last 64 tokens with the action, the mean Jensen–Shannon divergence of the top-5 next-token distributions, and the mean entropy difference.

C.3 Choice of the Signal and of θ

Before any intervention ran, an observation run of the Skill arm on the 140 valid_seen games logged every candidate signal at every step and never intervened (4,278 scored steps). Over the whole response, S_{lr} has median 0.36 and 90th percentile 0.80; over the action tokens alone, 0.00 and 0.001. The rule, written before the selection ran, oriented each candidate by its strict AUROC over 138 finished games (the episode's maximum value; positives are the 8 games that Skill lost in both of its runs and NoSkill won in both of its runs), set each candidate's threshold by the rule of Eq. (6), and sent the best candidate of each family to the development check.

Threshold search. The candidate set Θ holds the distinct values of the oriented signal on the 138 observation episodes that had finished when the rule ran (episodes 6 and 114 were being re-run after a server timeout); for the whole-response ratio these are 4,181 values, all distinct, so no ties arise. The code sorts Θ and bisects it for the smallest value whose mean firing rate $\bar{N}$ is at most 1.5, which assumes that $\bar{N}$ falls as θ rises. That holds only above the smallest scores: $\bar{N}$ is 1.0 at the smallest value (the Trigger fires at the first scored step and never re-arms), exceeds 1.5 from 0.059 to 0.9377 (at most 6.2 firings per episode) and stays at or below 1.5 from 0.9387 on. For the whole-response ratio, evaluating $\bar{N}$ at every value of Θ confirms that the bisection returns the smallest value from which $\bar{N} \le 1.5$ holds for all larger candidates, $\theta = 0.938709$ ($\bar{N} = 1.5$), which Eq. (6) states; the global minimum of $\{\theta' : \bar{N}(\theta') \le 1.5\}$ would instead be the smallest score (0.023), at which the Trigger fires once in every episode (we did not repeat this check for the candidates that were not selected). Had no candidate met the cap, the code would have returned the largest observed value; this did not occur for any candidate. The whole-response ratio separated best among the single signals (AUROC 0.80, 95% bootstrap interval $[0.67, 0.92]$; Jensen–Shannon 0.75, entropy difference 0.72, last-64-token window 0.70); its threshold is $\theta = 0.938709$ (0.9387 in the text), which 5.9% of the scored steps reach, and at it the trigger fires in all 8 positive games and in 60% of the others. Two combinations (a standardized mean of three signals, 0.75, and a two-stage gate, 0.82) went to the development check as well; all intervals overlap. Which signal and which intervention form

TRIM was then decided by development success (App. D.7).

C.4 Editor

Model and call. The editor is the agent's checkpoint, Qwen3-8B, called with thinking disabled, temperature 0, seed 0 and at most 1,200 output tokens, once per episode (at the first firing). It first writes NEEDS, what the task sentence asks for, from the task sentence alone (a separate call that sees nothing else); NEEDS is then fixed.

Inputs and verdicts. Figure 6 shows the verdict prompt. It holds the task, three harness facts, the initial observation and the last eight executed steps (observations clipped to 300 characters), the admissible actions, the drafted action [P], the last 1,500 characters of the draft's reasoning, the line-numbered block, NEEDS and the list of items with their current state. The editor gives every item one verdict (keep, withhold, replace with a corrected instruction, or restore an earlier change) and may add one instruction. Withheld items disappear from the block that the agent sees, replaced items show the corrected instruction, and an added instruction is appended; if the block changed, step t is regenerated from $x_t(K')$. The editor never sees S_{lr} or any outcome.

Parser behavior. The parser reads an output line "`ADD: NONE | ...`" as an added instruction, so the agent's block then ends with a line such as "None required"; the test runs use the same parser as the development runs that selected the method.

C.5 Withdrawal

At the second firing the editor is not called: the block is removed for the rest of the episode, so that every later prompt is the no-skill agent's prompt in the same state, and step t is regenerated with a fresh seed. Scoring stops, because there is no block to compare with. The episode continues from its current state; the next episode starts again with the retrieved block.

D Experimental Details

D.1 Additional Setup Details and Ablations

Benchmarks. The test set is the 134 `valid_unseen` games of six task types (24 Pick, 23 Heat, 21 Cool, 31 Clean, 18 Look and 17 PickTwo), as in prior ALFWorld agents (Yao et al., 2023; Chen et al., 2024), with the SkillRL prompt and action parser (App. C). SkillRL's SkillBank holds 44 retrievable skills (12 general, 32 task-specific). SRA-Bench ToolQA has questions that need external tools in seven domains; we use 50 questions from each of six (SciREX, on which our earlier non-thinking runs answer at most 2% of the questions correctly, is left out; App. D.3).

Setting	Value
Block injected from	step $t_0 = 2$ (BM25 top five)
Signal	S_{lr} over the whole response
Threshold θ	0.938709 (re-armed below θ)
First firing	editor review; regenerate if changed
Second firing	withdraw the block; regenerate
Editor input	8 steps, [P], 1,500 chars of reasoning
Editor decoding	thinking off, temperature 0, seed 0
Agent decoding	thinking, T 0.6, top-p 0.95, top-k 20
Episode budget	50 actions

Table 4: Settings of TRIM, fixed on the development games.

Backbones. Qwen3-8B uses Qwen3's recommended sampling (temperature 0.6, top-p 0.95, top-k 20) and at most 4,096 tokens per response; each request's seed is derived from the game and step and shared by all arms. We use thinking mode because without it loops of repeated actions cause most failures and hide misfit: on the development games, the agent wins 30 and 37 of 140 games without and with skills when thinking is off, and 64 and 71 when it is on.

Baselines. The prompting baseline adds one line above the block (App. D.4); *SkillAligner* rewrites the five skills into a task guide before the agent acts (our port); and *Planning* uses task-level plans to guide skill retrieval. The arms differ only in which skills reach the prompt and how they are handled.

Metrics. Success is the share of games won within 50 actions; TRIM uses seed bases 1701–1703 and each baseline shares TRIM's first seed base. "a:b games" counts the games that only one arm wins, tested with a two-sided exact sign test (Dror et al., 2018); effects are differences in per-game success, in percentage points, with 95% bootstrap intervals over games (Koehn, 2004), using TRIM's success rate per game over its three runs. Because batched serving changes outcomes between reruns even with fixed seeds (Yuan et al., 2025) (about 11% of development outcomes; App. B.3), we rely on per-game comparisons rather than on small differences in totals.

```
You are checking the skill text given to an agent that acts in a text-based household environment
    (ALFWorld). The agent is in the middle of its episode.
## Task [G]
{GOAL}
## Harness facts
[H1] At every step the agent outputs one action inside <action></action>; only that action is executed.
    It should be one of the admissible actions listed for that step, otherwise the environment answers
    "Nothing happens." From step 2 on the agent sees the skill text below, its last 2 observation/action
    pairs and the current observation.
[H2] The episode succeeds as soon as the state described by the task [G] holds; nothing else is checked.
    The episode ends after 50 actions.
[H3] Objects and locations exist only if they appear in an observation or an admissible action, under
    those exact names (e.g. 'countertop 1', 'apple 2').
## Episode so far (actions and observations)
[O0] Initial observation: {...}   Action {k}: {...}   [O{k}] Observation {k}: {...}   (last 8 steps)
## Admissible actions at the current step [A]
{...}
## The agent's proposed next action (not executed yet) [P]
{DRAFTED ACTION}
## The agent's reasoning before [P] (end of it)
{LAST 1,500 CHARACTERS OF THE DRAFT'S REASONING}
## Skill text (line-numbered)
{S1:L1| ... }
## NEEDS (from the task sentence)
{NEEDS}
## Skill items (the state the agent currently sees)
I{k} = S1:L{a}-L{b} "{TITLE}": original | WITHHELD | REPLACED with: {...}
Added instruction in effect: none
## Your task
The skill text was retrieved for this task automatically and may not fit it. NEEDS below was written
    from the task sentence alone; use it as given.
Then give a verdict for EVERY skill item listed under 'Skill items', given what has been observed so far:
- KEEP: leave the item as the agent currently sees it (the default, also when unsure).
- WITHHOLD: following the item would make the agent do something NEEDS does not contain, or its condition
    can never hold here or is ruled out by the observations.
- REPLACE: the item's idea serves NEEDS but a detail is wrong for this task or episode; give the corrected
    instruction.
- RESTORE: an earlier change to this item was wrong; the agent should see the original item again.
If NEEDS requires a step or check that no item covers and the episode so far shows the agent missing it,
    give it as ADD (at most one).
- A condition in an item ('Apply when', 'after', 'once', 'before') may describe a LATER moment of the
    episode. Do not withhold an item only because its condition is not true yet; withhold it only if the
    condition can never hold for this task or the observations rule it out.
- Never withhold, and never leave withheld, an item that helps achieve something in NEEDS; if such an
    item is currently withheld, RESTORE it.
- Never RESTORE or ADD anything that asks for an action, object or change that NEEDS does not contain.
- Write instructions to the agent, not explanations. Use only actions, objects and locations that appear
    in the task, the observations, the admissible actions or the skill text.
- Every change must cite its evidence: [G] the task, [H1]/[H2]/[H3] a harness fact, [O<k>] observation k,
    [A] the admissible actions, [P] the proposed action.
Output exactly this and nothing else:
ITEMS:
- I<k> | KEEP, WITHHOLD, REPLACE or RESTORE | <evidence tag(s)> | <short reason, or the instruction for
    REPLACE; at most 25 words>
(one line per item, in order)
ADD: NONE, or ADD: <evidence tag(s)> | <instruction; at most 30 words>
```

Figure 6: The editor's verdict prompt at the first firing (template; blank lines removed). NEEDS comes from an earlier call that sees only the task sentence: "NEEDS = everything the task sentence [G] asks for: the outcome, every object, place or value it names, and every property it attributes to an object … a state the agent must PRODUCE, not a state that already holds."

Main results by task type. TRIM gains most over the retrieved skills on Cool (76.2% against 52.4%) and Pick (58.3% against 37.5%); with Qwen3-14B, over three runs, SkillAligner is the strongest baseline (51.0%; per-run counts in Table 6), against 54.5% for TRIM in its one run so far (73 wins); against run 1 of each baseline, which shares its seeds, it wins 22:10 games over NoSkill, 17:7 over Skill, 12:7 over prompting and 21:10 over SkillAligner (run 1 only; exact sign tests, $p = 0.050$, 0.064, 0.36 and 0.071). Over three runs TRIM wins 75, 71 and 65 games, on average 10.3 more than Skill's 60. With Qwen3-14B it is ahead of Skill in 40 games and behind in 20 (games one arm wins more often over the three runs; $p = 0.01$). Over three runs of each arm, it is ahead of prompting in 40:23 games with Qwen3-8B and 41:21 with Qwen3-14B (exact sign tests, $p = 0.043$ and 0.015) and of SkillAligner in 48:26 and 38:24 ($p = 0.014$ and 0.098), before any correction for multiple comparisons. As a secondary analysis, pooling the 268 game–backbone pairs gives 81:44 and 86:50 ($p = 0.001$ and 0.003); this treats the two backbones' results on the same game as independent units, which they need not be. On ToolQA it answers more questions than Skill (40:21 and 32:17 questions, $p = 0.02$ and 0.04).

Ablation details. One TRIM episode did not finish, so variants are compared on the 139 games both finished; the signals and steps compared while developing TRIM, which edit at every firing, are in App. D.7. Pairs below count the games only TRIM or only the variant wins (Table 2); against no intervention, the Skill observation run, TRIM wins 13:9 games.Without the withdrawal (14:10 games for TRIM), the variant rescues 3 of the 15 games that the skills harm, against 9 (App. Table 10); the restored-state test continued each of the 42 states twice with the edited block kept and twice without it (App. D.8). Withdrawing at the first firing gives 14:13 games. Replacing the first edit with a plain regeneration of the step lowers success to 48.6% (13:8 games) and rescues 5 of the 15 harmed games, against 9. Withdrawing at a random step after the signal's edit, instead of at the second firing, lowers success to 48.6% (16:10 games) and rescues 4 harmed games, against 9. The whole-response ratio was chosen among five signals before these ablations; it separates the harmed games best (AUROC 0.80 against 0.70–0.75; App. C.3). A one-time edit at step 2 (PRE, the editor's review at injection without a second stage) wins 46.5% of the test episodes over three runs, against 52.5% for TRIM (App. Table 8). The random-step control fires at each step with a fixed probability, set from TRIM's firing rate on the development games, and applies the same two stages. Over three runs TRIM wins 211 of 402 test episodes against 187 for PRE and 190 for RAND (34:15 and 35:12 games, $p = 0.009$ and 0.001) while firing 350 times against RAND's 380, and withdrawal at the signal's state beats withdrawal at the nearest or a random state without a firing (+9.5 and +10.1 points; Table 11).

Lost wins and length. Table 5 adds length and generation to the lost wins of Figure 3. On the 26 games that all its arms solve, TRIM takes 9.3 actions against Skill's 8.2 and NoSkill's 11.5. In runs 2 and 3, TRIM loses 7 and 14 of NoSkill's 57 wins and 7 and 11 of Skill's 60. With Qwen3-14B (run 1), TRIM loses 10 of NoSkill's 61 wins and 7 of Skill's 63; Skill, prompting and SkillAligner lose 15, 12 and 14 of NoSkill's wins, and NoSkill, prompting and SkillAligner 17, 7 and 12 of Skill's.

	Lost of			Tokens
Arm	NoSkill	Skill	Steps	Gen. (k)
NoSkill	–	24	11.5	38.1
Skill	21	–	8.2	32.0
+ prompting	18	6	9.4	30.5
SkillAligner	19	18	9.3	35.8
TRIM	10	4	9.3	31.0

Table 5: Lost wins, length and generation (Qwen3-8B, thinking, test run 1). Lost: wins of NoSkill (57) or Skill (60) that the arm loses. Steps: mean actions on the 26 games all arms solve. Gen.: generated tokens per episode, with editor calls.

D.2 Runs and Servers

The test set is `valid_unseen` (134 games: Pick 24, Heat 23, Cool 21, Clean 31, Look 18, PickTwo 17) and the development set `valid_seen` (140 games); decoding and retrieval are as in App. C. The baselines (NoSkill, Skill, prompting and SkillAligner, with both backbones) ran on a local vLLM 0.8.5 server (two RTX A5000 GPUs, tensor parallel); TRIM, PRE, RAND, all development arms of TRIM and the same-state study ran on cloud A100 80GB GPUs with vLLM 0.29.0. The local server separates the reasoning with vLLM's `deepseek_r1` parser and the cloud server with its `qwen3` parser; both apply Qwen3's chat template with thinking enabled, so every comparison of TRIM with an ALFWorld baseline crosses the two servers. Both runners draw the first draft of each step with the same seed formula, so arms share seeds at the same game and step; neither server is batch-invariant. On the development games, the Skill arm wins 71 of 140 on the local server and 70 on the cloud server. Episodes that ended in an infrastructure error were re-run; one SkillAligner game (Qwen3-8B) failed in all three attempts and is excluded from that arm's counts and paired tests. TRIM and the two controls ran three times on the test games (seed bases 1701, 1702 and 1703), NoSkill and Skill with Qwen3-8B once (1701), prompting and SkillAligner with Qwen3-8B three times (1701–1703; wins 67, 58, 57 and 65 of 133, 57, 56), and each Qwen3-14B baseline three times with one configuration and server (Table 6); the Qwen3-14B Planning runs on ALFWorld use the same server, with the planning call also in thinking mode. TRIM with Qwen3-14B has run once on the test games so far (seed base 1701), on the cloud server like the Qwen3-8B runs of TRIM, so its comparisons with the Qwen3-14B baselines also cross the two servers; its $\theta = 1.142$ is set by the rule of §4.2 on an observation run of Qwen3-14B on the 140 development games.

Arm	Run	Pick	Heat	Cool	Clean	Look	Two	All
NoSkill	r1	16/24	9/23	11/21	15/31	10/18	0/17	61/134
	r2	18/24	8/23	10/21	12/31	8/18	1/17	57/134
	r3	18/24	10/23	7/21	11/31	9/18	2/17	57/134
Skill	r1	14/24	6/23	10/21	20/31	12/18	1/17	63/134
	r2	17/24	7/23	12/21	20/31	12/18	1/17	69/134
	r3	18/24	6/23	9/21	20/31	13/18	1/17	67/134
A6	r1	16/24	7/23	12/21	18/31	14/18	1/17	68/134
	r2	17/24	5/23	9/21	18/31	12/18	1/17	62/134
	r3	16/24	9/23	11/21	20/31	12/18	0/17	68/134
SkillAligner	r1	16/24	4/23	9/21	21/31	9/18	3/17	62/134
	r2	20/24	7/23	9/21	19/31	12/18	4/17	71/134
	r3	19/24	6/23	12/21	20/31	12/18	3/17	72/134
Planning	r1	16/24	7/23	13/21	19/31	13/18	0/17	68/134
	r2	15/24	12/23	13/21	21/31	13/18	1/17	75/134
	r3	16/24	8/23	15/21	21/31	14/18	1/17	75/134
TRIM	r1	20/24	6/23	13/21	17/31	13/18	4/17	73/134

Table 6: Qwen3-14B on the ALFWorld test games, wins / finished games per run (thinking mode); TRIM ran once (cloud server, App. D.2). Green: run in progress (snapshot 2026-10-12 11:46 UTC = 20:46 KST); ·: no result yet.

Model	Arm	Flt.	Cof.	Yelp	Abnb.	Agd.	DBLP	All
Qwen3-8B	NoSkill	7/50	19/50	24/50	11/50	8/50	10/50	79/300
	Skill	27/50	32/50	29/50	21/50	4/50	10/50	123/300
	A6	28/50	32/50	25/50	20/50	3/50	13/50	121/300
	SkillAligner	25/50	20/50	26/50	16/50	4/50	5/50	96/300
	Planning	20/50	25/50	21/50	18/50	4/50	10/50	98/300
	TRIM	27/50	29/50	26/50	18/50	1/50	12/50	113/300
Qwen3-14B	NoSkill	18/50	22/50	29/50	18/50	5/50	15/50	107/300
	Skill	25/50	36/50	20/50	16/50	3/50	16/50	116/300
	A6	26/50	35/50	20/50	14/50	4/50	10/50	109/300
	SkillAligner	27/50	26/50	26/50	21/50	0/50	7/50	107/300
	Planning	23/50	27/50	20/50	10/50	5/50	11/50	96/300
	TRIM	24/50	37/50	20/50	10/50	4/50	13/50	108/300

Table 7: ToolQA in thinking mode, correct / finished questions per domain (one run, 50 per domain). Green: run in progress (snapshot 2026-10-12 11:46 UTC = 20:46 KST); ·: no result yet.

D.3 ToolQA in Thinking Mode

The ToolQA runs use 300 questions, 50 from each of six domains, one pass per arm, with the ReAct agent of SRA-Bench (at most 12 steps), Qwen3's thinking decoding and at most 4,096 tokens per step; every arm and both backbones run on cloud A100 80GB GPUs with vLLM 0.29 and its `qwen3` reasoning parser. Skill is the frozen top-5 BM25 block of each question; prompting, SkillAligner and Planning are as on ALFWorld, and Planning's plan call also runs in thinking mode. TRIM is unchanged except for θ: a ToolQA episode scores only 4.4 (Qwen3-8B) or 4.7 (Qwen3-14B) steps on average, so the rule of at most 1.5 firings per episode never binds; instead, θ keeps ALFWorld's share of firing steps, the smallest value reached by at most 5.891% of the scored steps of an observation run on 120 development questions disjoint from the 300 ($\theta = 0.770$ for Qwen3-8B and 0.758 for Qwen3-14B; 5.86% and 5.71% of the steps reach it). A question counts once its episode ends without an infrastructure error (a context overflow counts as wrong); infrastructure errors are re-run. The runs were still in progress at the snapshot (2026-10-12 11:46 UTC = 20:46 KST); Table 7 gives the questions finished per domain, and a value turns black in Table 1 only when its run has counted all 300 questions and has finished its re-run pass.

D.4 Prompting Baseline

The prompting baseline puts one line directly above the BM25 block; the block itself is byte-identical to Skill. The line is adapted from a prompt used in a pilot study and made plural because the block holds several skills.

> **Prompting.** These skills were written without seeing your environment: treat them as a reference, adapt them to the tools and feedback you actually get, and still do any step the task needs even if the skills omit it:

D.5 Baseline Ports

SkillAligner (port). We re-implemented SkillAligner (Li et al., 2026b) from the prompts in its appendix; we did not use the authors' code. Before the episode, the agent's model makes one adaptation call (temperature 1 as in the paper, top-p 1, seed 0, at most 2,048 output tokens; the output cap and seed are our choices). Its input is the goal sentence, the five retrieved skills and, in the slot for the environment, ALFWorld's action format and step budget; it never sees the initial observation, the game identity or a solution. The output must be a JSON object with the string lists *Primary*, *Checks*, *Avoid* and *Fallback*. There is no repair or retry, and a schema failure counts as a failed episode (3 of 133 Qwen3-8B episodes). The guide replaces the raw block in the same slot from step 2 on and stays fixed.

Planning (port). Planning is our port of SkillX (Wang et al., 2026a): one planning call per episode sees only the goal, each plan step is a BM25 query over the same index, and the hits fill the same slot up to five skills. It was run with thinking off in the non-thinking version of our experiments; in thinking mode (the planning call also thinks), it ran on ALFWorld three times with each of Qwen3-8B (56, 61 and 65 wins of 134) and Qwen3-14B (68, 75 and 75), and it also runs on

Arm	Pick	Heat	Cool	Clean	Look	Two	All	Runs
PRE	61.1	37.7	55.6	51.6	48.1	15.7	46.5	63, 63, 61
RAND	50.0	46.4	55.6	53.8	53.7	15.7	47.3	65, 62, 63
TRIM	58.3	50.7	68.3	53.8	55.6	21.6	52.5	75, 71, 65

Table 8: Success (%) over three test runs (402 episodes) of a one-time edit at injection (PRE) and of the two stages at random steps (RAND), and of TRIM, per task type (Qwen3-8B, thinking; Two: PickTwo). Runs: wins in runs 1, 2 and 3; PRE reviews at step 2, RAND fires with $p = 0.029$ per step.

ToolQA with both backbones.

Absolute success rates. SkillAligner reports, for Qwen3-8B on ALFWorld, 52.99% without skills, 61.94% with raw top-k skills and 80.60% with SkillAligner (Li et al., 2026b); in our harness the same backbone in thinking mode reaches 42.5%, 44.8% and 48.9% (our port). The harnesses differ: we use SkillRL's released ALFWorld agent loop (its prompt, two steps of history, at most 50 actions), whereas SkillAligner uses its own prompts and execution protocol. We therefore compare methods only within one harness and make no claim about absolute rates.

Not reproduced. SelSkill (Chen et al., 2026) releases training and evaluation code but no trained selector checkpoint; reproducing it would require its GRPO initialization and three rounds of preference training, which falls outside our training-free comparison.

D.6 Timing Controls and Paired Tests

PRE and RAND share TRIM's runner, editor, regeneration and withdrawal rule and differ only in when they fire. PRE fires once, at step 2, so its second stage never occurs. RAND draws a seeded coin at every step from step 2 on, with $p = 0.0289$, TRIM's number of firings per scored step on the development games; its coin depends only on the game and step, never on the episode. Table 8 gives their success per task type and Table 9 every paired test of TRIM. Over the three runs, TRIM fires 350 times (0.87 per episode; a first firing in 246 episodes, a withdrawal in 104) and RAND 380 times (0.95; 238 and 142), with 211 and 190 wins of 402 episodes; PRE wins 187.

D.7 Development Runs and Selection

All development arms ran on the 140 valid_seen games with the same seeds as the no-edit observation run, and each is paired with it (Table 10). Strata come from two runs each of Skill and NoSkill, one of which is the observation run; comparisons with the observation run therefore regress to the mean (it wins none of the harmed games by definition, whereas episodes of other arms without any edit win 5 of 22 there). The first seven arms test signals and timings with edits only, at every firing, with an editor that does not yet see the reasoning excerpt. Their trajectories showed that the editor rarely changed the action and never removed the search items behind most harmed games (App. B), and the method was revised once within the same trigger: five candidates (the second group of Table 10) were compared by a rule registered before their results: highest development success, ties broken by fewer firings per episode. Edit-then-withdraw won the comparison (73 of 139; 0.521 even if its unfinished episode were lost, against at

TRIM	X:Y	p	Holm	Δ	95% CI
vs. PRE	22:10	0.050	0.200	+9.0	[0.7, 17.2]
vs. RAND	20:10	0.099	0.296	+7.5	[−0.7, 15.7]
vs. Skill	19:4	0.003	0.016	+11.2	[4.5, 17.9]
vs. NoSkill	28:10	0.005	0.025	+13.4	[4.5, 22.4]
vs. prompting	17:9	0.169	0.337	+6.0	[−1.5, 13.4]
vs. SkillAligner	29:19	0.193	0.337	+7.5	[−2.3, 17.3]
Runs 1–3 (X:Y: games one arm wins more often)					
vs. PRE	34:15	0.009	–	+6.0	[0.5, 11.4]
vs. RAND	35:12	0.001	–	+5.2	[0.2, 10.2]
Other pairs (X vs. Y)					
Skill vs. NoSkill	24:21	0.766	–	+2.2	[−7.5, 11.9]
RAND vs. PRE	15:13	0.851	–	+1.5	[−6.0, 9.0]

Table 9: Paired tests on the 134 test games (133 with SkillAligner; Qwen3-8B, test run 1 unless marked; runs 1–3 against the baselines: Figure 7). X:Y: games won by one arm only; p: exact sign test; Holm: over TRIM's six run-1 tests; Δ: success difference (points) with a bootstrap CI over games.

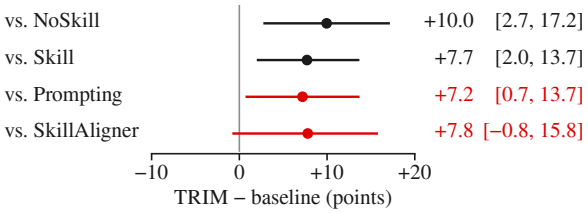


Figure 7: TRIM against each baseline on the 134 test games (Qwen3-8B, thinking): per-game success of TRIM averaged over its three runs (75, 71 and 65 wins) minus the baseline's mean over its runs (prompting and SkillAligner: three runs; NoSkill and Skill: one run), in points, with 95% bootstrap CIs over games (133 games for SkillAligner); run-1 tests: App. Table 9.

Arm	Won	Harmed	Needed	Fir.
No edit (Skill)	70/140	0/15	20/20	0.00
Edits only, at the steps of				
S_{lr}	66/140	3/15	15/20	1.46
JSD	62/140	4/15	12/20	1.09
Entropy	65/140	4/15	12/20	1.09
Combination	66/140	4/15	15/20	1.16
Two-stage gate	65/140	3/15	16/20	1.33
Random steps	70/140	5/15	17/20	1.59
Step 2	63/140	3/15	11/20	1.00
Revised interventions (S_{lr})				
Reasoning, $\leq$3 reviews	68/139	3/15	18/20	1.03
Edit, then withdraw	**73/139**	9/15	15/19	0.91
Withdraw at once	72/140	7/15	10/20	0.61
Attribution, one item	70/140	3/15	17/20	1.17
Arbitration	71/139	3/15	18/20	1.06
Two stages, random steps	69/140	5/15	16/20	1.10
Ablations of TRIM				
Edit only (one review)	69/140	3/15	14/20	0.61
Regenerate, then withdraw	68/140	5/15	15/20	0.92
Edit, random withdrawal	68/140	4/15	14/20	0.91

Table 10: Development arms (140 valid_seen games, Qwen3-8B, thinking). Harmed: games Skill lost in both of its runs and NoSkill won at least once; Needed: Skill won both, NoSkill at most one. Fir.: firings per episode. Bold: TRIM, chosen by the registered rule. Ablations: registered after the choice.

most 0.514 for every other candidate) and became TRIM; the random-timing version of the same intervention was run as its control. Withdrawing a third firing and a variant of the signal measured against the episode's own course were stopped part-way to save budget and are not used. Because TRIM was selected among these candidates on the same games, its development numbers are optimistic. After the choice, three component ablations were registered and run once each with the same seeds (last group of Table 10): one review without withdrawal, a plain regeneration of the step instead of the edit at the first firing, and the signal's edit followed by a withdrawal at a random step ($p = 0.0318$ per step, TRIM's rate of second firings on the development games).

D.8 Pre-registered Criteria and Component Tests

The signal, θ, the editor and the two controls were fixed on the development games, and the test games were run once (r1), with no change of method afterwards. Before any repeat result, we registered that TRIM counts as effective if its mean wins over three runs exceed Skill's 60 by five or more and it beats PRE in every run, the comparison with RAND being reported, not required: the first condition holds (mean 70.3) and so does the second (75, 71 and 65 wins against 63, 63 and 61), so TRIM meets it (Table 8).

Comparison (development)	n	Δ	95% CI
Timing: d = win rate withdrawn − kept			
d(signal) − d(nearest)	74	+9.5	[0.7, 18.2]
d(signal) − d(random)	74	+10.1	[0.7, 19.6]
d: $\geq$2 firings − one firing*	41/33	+16.5	[1.6, 32.0]
d(signal) by stratum (episodes)			
harmed +38.5 (13), needed −34.6 (13), easy 0.0 (14), mixed +37.5 (8), fail either way +20.0 (25)			
Second firing: win rate of continuations			
withdraw − keep edited	42	+11.9	[1.2, 22.6]
withdraw − restore original	33	+4.5	[−9.1, 18.2]
restore original − keep edited	33	+9.1	[−3.0, 21.2]

Table 11: Component tests on restored development states (Qwen3-8B, thinking; two continuations per branch). Δ in points; bootstrap CIs over episodes or states. *Grouping examined after the runs.

Before their results we also registered tests on the development games, each restoring logged episodes by replaying their actions (every restored prompt equals the logged one) and continuing them to the 50-step limit twice per branch with fixed seeds and no further intervention (Table 11). *Timing*: in each of the 74 observation-run episodes in which the signal fired by step 40, three states are restored: the signal's (its second firing, or its only one), the nearest step without a firing and a random step without a firing; each continues with the block kept and with it withdrawn, and d is the win rate without the block minus that with it. *Second firing*: at the 42 states where TRIM withdrew the block, the continuations keep the edited block (E), withdraw it (N) or restore the original block (O, at the 33 states whose block the edit had changed). After the timing runs, we grouped their episodes by whether the signal had fired at least twice (§6); a check of this grouping on the test games, restoring every episode still running at step 10 and grouping it by its firings up to then, was registered before its observation run.

E Additional Analysis

When the arms intervene. Table 13 lists, for TRIM and the two controls, how often and when they fire and how the episodes end. Of TRIM's 81 reviews, 64 change the block and 17 leave it unchanged; a second firing follows in 34 episodes. RAND fires more often per episode (0.95 firings

Experiment	Question	Result
Repeated firing, held-out check (test)	does it mark where withdrawal helps?	[NaN]
Further runs against random steps (test)	fewer firings, higher success?	[NaN]
TRIM with Qwen3-14B (test)	other backbone (run 1 done)	Table 1
ToolQA in thinking mode, all arms	other benchmark	interim
Planning port on ALFWorld, Qwen3-14B (thinking)	baseline	running

Table 12: Experiments of this version that are running or planned.

	PRE	RAND	TRIM
Episodes with a firing	134	80	81
edits changing the block	125	79	64
withdrawn episodes	0	47	34
First firing: median [IQR]	2	14 [6, 28]	4 [2, 10]
Withdrawal: median [IQR]	–	27 [17, 41]	15 [9, 20]
Wins: no firing	–	46/54	27/53
firing, not withdrawn	63/134	12/33	29/47
withdrawn	–	7/47	19/34

Table 13: When the edit and the withdrawal happen and how the episodes end (Qwen3-8B, thinking, test run 1, 134 games). IQR: interquartile range of the step.

against TRIM's 0.86) and later, so its withdrawals fall in long episodes that are mostly lost by then. Over the three runs, TRIM's first firing has a median step of 4 in every run and its withdrawal of 15, 11.5 and 11.5, against 14, 12 and 15 and 27, 24 and 29 for RAND; TRIM fires 350 times in all and RAND 380. In 139 of TRIM's 191 lost episodes over the three runs, the agent never picks up the target (RAND: 157 of 212; PRE: 155 of 215).

Firings by development stratum. On the development observation run, the re-armed Trigger fires 3.07 times per episode in the 15 games the skills harm, 1.45 in the 20 that need them, 0.59 in the 44 easy games, 1.62 in the 13 mixed ones and 1.79 in the 47 that fail either way; it fires at least twice in 11, 8, 2, 5 and 19 of them.

The signal on the test games. Over TRIM's 3,384 scored test steps, S_{lr} has median 0.28 and 90th percentile 0.70, and 4.0% of the steps reach θ, against 0.36, 0.80 and 5.9% on the development observation run where θ was set; the test steps are fewer per episode because scoring stops after a withdrawal.

Cost. Scoring prefills the drafted response under both prompts at every step until a withdrawal: 79.6k prompt tokens per episode for TRIM, 2.6 times the 31.0k tokens it generates (Table 5). The prefills need no generation and took 8.5% of the episodes' wall-clock time; reading the skill-on log-probabilities at generation time would remove one of the two prefills, which we have not implemented. Editor calls add 1.4k tokens per episode. Wall-clock times are not comparable across our two servers, which ran at different concurrency.

F Case Studies

The cases come from the single test run with Qwen3-8B in thinking mode and were chosen after it; they illustrate mechanisms, not frequencies, and the supplementary material lists the file and line of every quoted step. All three wins below are cooling tasks in the same kitchen layout whose block holds the same search item; in none does the action at a firing step change, so the effect of an intervention shows only in later steps.

The game of Figure 2. Task: "cool some potato and put it in microwave." The block holds Open Before Judging Empty, Track Counts & Progress, Open Then Heat (a heating procedure), Systematic Object Hunt and Secure Exact Target First. With TRIM, S_{lr} stays between 0.31 and 0.84 at steps 2–9 while the agent searches the cabinets, and most drafts cite a skill item. At step 10 ("open cabinet 5", 1.12), the editor withholds Open Then Heat, giving the reason that it "hasn't happened yet", which its prompt forbids, and keeps the four other items. S_{lr} falls to 0.39 at step 11 and reaches 1.66 at step 12 ("open cabinet 6"), whose draft reads "according to the systematic object hunt skill, I should sweep every unvisited surface and open containers until the exact object is found"; the block is withdrawn. The agent revisits the fridge and three cabinets, goes to the sink basin at step 18 and to the countertop at step 19 ("Maybe the potato is on the countertop."), and wins at step 25. Skill shares the first six actions and then visits only the fridge and cabinets 1–6 until step 50; its reasoning cites skill items in 46 of 49 steps. NoSkill goes to the countertop at step 3 and wins at step 9; PRE makes the same edit at step 2 and loses; SkillAligner's guide turns the heating item into "Cool the potato with the microwave" and loses; prompting loses. RAND also wins this game (edit at step 5, withdrawal at step 21); the case shows how a withdrawal ends the search loop, and the withdrawal steps are compared over all episodes in App. D.8. The signal did not fire at step

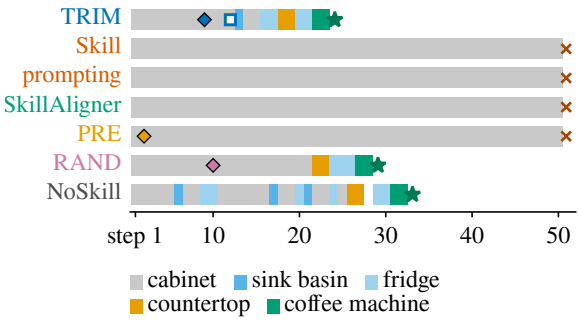


Figure 8: Where each arm goes in one test game, "cool some mug and put it in coffeemachine" (post hoc). Diamond: edit; square: withdrawal; star: goal done; cross: 50 steps used. PRE: TRIM's Editor once, at step 2; RAND: both stages at random steps. TRIM's first 12 prompts equal Skill's.

3, where Skill and NoSkill first part (0.72).

An edit that keeps the misfitting item. Task: "put a cool tomato in microwave." At step 2, the first scored step, the draft reads "using the 'Open Then Heat' skill, I should open the microwave door, place the tomato inside, and heat it" ($S_{\mathrm{lr}} = 1.32$). The editor's NEEDS misreads the task as heating ("the tomato is heated in the microwave"), and it keeps all five items. At step 5 the signal fires again (1.25; the draft cites the search item) and the block is withdrawn. The next six actions equal Skill's; at step 12 the agent goes to the countertop and at step 13 to the sink basin, where it finds the tomato, and it wins at step 25. Skill, PRE (the same all-keep review at step 2), RAND (edit at step 12, withdrawal at step 37), SkillAligner and prompting all lose. NoSkill wins at step 24.

The same history until the withdrawal (Figure 8). Task: "cool some mug and put it in coffeemachine." For steps 1–12, TRIM's prompts are identical to Skill's. At step 9 ($S_{\mathrm{lr}} = 1.67$) the editor keeps all items, including a cleaning procedure whose condition cannot hold in a cooling task; at step 12 (1.16) the block is withdrawn. At step 13 the agent leaves the cabinets for the sink basin, finds the mug at step 18 and wins at step 23, whereas Skill, SkillAligner, prompting and PRE visit only cabinets 1–6 for 50 steps. NoSkill wins at step 32; RAND wins as well, after an edit at step 10 that withholds the search item.

Games TRIM loses and Skill wins. All four diverge from Skill before TRIM's first firing, or never fire. (i) "put a clean soapbar in countertop": the editor withholds both cleaning items because the bar is "already clean per task"; after the withdrawal at step 16 the agent never cleans it. (ii) "clean some soapbar and put it in countertop": the editor withholds a helpful location item; the agent then loops through four cabinets for 46 steps with $S_{\mathrm{lr}} \leq 0.85$, so the block is never withdrawn. (iii) "cool some pan and put it in countertop": no firing until step 30; the agent finds the pan at step 16 but never cools it. (iv) "put a hot tomato in garbagecan": no firing at all ($S_{\mathrm{lr}} \leq 0.83$), although the drafts at steps 9, 10 and 13 cite a cooling item and the agent goes to the fridge at step 11, with S_{lr} between 0.24 and 0.36 at those steps.